10-26 第1篇

阅读理解（说明文） The Dawn Chorus: Why Do Birds Sing Before Sunrise?

① If you have ever slept with the window slightly open in spring or autumn, you may have been woken at about **four thirty in the morning** by a soft, busy sound — many small throats singing together, long before the sky has fully turned blue. Scientists call this quiet uproar "the **dawn chorus**". For hundreds of years, farmers and poets loved it; only in the last fifty years have researchers begun to ask the interesting question: **why sing so early, when the world is still dark?**

② The first reason has to do with **air**. In the cool, still hours before sunrise, the air is thin, quiet and carries almost no wind. Sound waves travel **far** in this calm sky — up to **twenty times farther** than at noon. A singing male sparrow on a birch tree can be heard by other birds **a kilometre away**. Later in the day, once the wind picks up and traffic grows louder, the same song can only reach the next garden. So, to "speak" to a large audience, birds choose the loudest microphone the world offers: the **silent dawn**.

③ The second reason is about **safety**. Small singing birds are easy snacks for hawks and other daytime hunters. At dawn, the world is still too dark for most hawks to hunt well; the singer can therefore stand high on a branch, open his beak wide, and "shout" without being spotted. As soon as the full sun rises, many singers become quiet again and slip down into the bushes — the "chorus" is a short, safer window.

④ Third, there is **love and land**. Most dawn singers are **male**. Their song says two things at the same time: **"I am strong enough to spend energy on music" and "this tree is mine"**. Females listen; rival males also listen. A male who sings longer, cleaner, and higher tends to win both a partner and a larger "living room". In a way, the dawn chorus is a very old radio programme about **who is home and who is available**.

⑤ A surprising fourth reason was found only recently. Studies in the United Kingdom and in Wuhan between 2015 and 2023 have shown that the **loudest notes are often the first ones**, sung before insects wake up. At this time, there is little food flying in the air, so singing burns energy with less "return". Scientists now believe that a bird who sings well even on an **empty stomach** is telling the neighbourhood: "**Look how healthy I am — I can afford to lose this energy.**" Only very fit males can keep up such a show.

⑥ Not every bird joins the chorus at the same moment. There is a **clear order**, a little like instruments coming in at the start of a symphony. In many Chinese cities, the first voice is often the **magpie-robin** (鹊鸲), followed by the **common blackbird**, then the **sparrow**, and finally, as the sky brightens, the **grey-starling**. A careful listener, with

practice, can tell the time to the nearest ten minutes just by hearing who has started singing.

⑦ Sadly, the chorus is slowly becoming **thinner** in big cities. Night-time light keeps some birds singing at the wrong hours; tall buildings break the old flight paths; and **traffic noise before six in the morning** has risen sharply in the last twenty years. Research in Beijing, Chengdu and Shenzhen shows that city dawn choruses are now about **30% quieter** than those in nearby forests. Some cities, like Kunming, have tried a simple cure: turning down the early-morning bus horns and lowering the lights in some parks between 04:00 and 06:00. The first reports are hopeful; the birds **sing back**, sooner and louder, within a single season.

⑧ So, if you happen to wake early one quiet morning and hear that thin, busy music drifting in through the window, pause for a minute. You are listening to a small, free concert that has been playing above our cities every spring and autumn for **tens of millions of years**. It is also one of the easiest ways to know whether our piece of sky is still alive. **A morning full of birds is a morning worth waking up for.**

注释： dawn chorus 黎明合唱；sparrow 麻雀；hawk 鹰；magpie-robin 鹊鸲；blackbird 乌鸫

根据短文内容，选择最佳答案。

1. According to Paragraph ②, why does a bird's dawn song travel so far?

A. Because the bird's throat is bigger in the morning.
B. Because the cool, still dawn air is quiet and almost windless, so sound waves can travel up to twenty times farther than at noon.
C. Because the trees are shorter in the morning.
D. Because there are no clouds at dawn.

2. Why is singing at dawn SAFER for small birds?

A. Because they are hiding in their nests.
B. Because it is still too dark for most daytime hunters like hawks to hunt well.
C. Because farmers protect them at dawn.
D. Because they sing underground.

3. What do male birds tell other birds through their dawn song, according to Paragraph ④?

A. "I am very hungry."
B. "I am strong enough to spend energy on music, and this tree is mine."
C. "I need a new nest."
D. "Please leave me alone."

4. What did studies in the UK and Wuhan between 2015 and 2023 find?

A. Birds sing louder only when they are full.
B. The loudest notes are often the first ones, sung before insects wake up; a healthy male can afford to spend energy on music with little "food return".
C. Birds never sing on an empty stomach.
D. Only female birds sing at dawn.

5. According to Paragraph ⑦, what cure has Kunming tried, and what happened?

A. Kunming banned all parks, but nothing changed.
B. Kunming cut down the tall trees, and the birds left.
C. Kunming turned down early-morning bus horns and lowered park lights between 04:00 and 06:00, and the birds sang back sooner and louder within a single season.
D. Kunming bought birds from other cities.

答案与解析

1.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第②段 "sound waves travel far ... up to twenty times farther than at noon"
【解析】平静空气使声音远传。A、C、D 均错。故选 B。

2.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第③段 "the world is still too dark for most hawks to hunt well"
【解析】黎明天未亮，猛禽难觅食。A、C、D 均错。故选 B。

3.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第④段 "I am strong enough ... this tree is mine"
【解析】双重信息直引。A、C、D 均错。故选 B。

4.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第⑤段 "loudest notes are often the first ones ... sung before insects wake up ... 'Look how healthy I am'"
【解析】"空腹献艺"显示健康。A、C、D 均错。故选 B。

5.
【答案】C

【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第⑦段 "Kunming ... turning down the early-morning bus horns and lowering the lights ... sing back, sooner and louder"
【解析】措施与效果直引。A、B、D 均错。故选 C。